

makes sense, but localising an English product into Hindi will not do much. A game meant for the Indian market is where we see benefits. A game, or an add-on to a popular game, on Kargil or Kashmir, would be more compelling than translating an English title into Hindi." He adds that, currently, games are a cultural import and as such an out-and-out translation would lose the essence of the message. "Subject matter would also be one of the reasons for the compulsion—a *Tom and Jerry* title could be fun in Hindi, but *Lord of the Rings*? We did do limited localisation for game boxes, but the exercise met with consumer backlash, espe-

tributor to handle. "Indian distributors need to band together and approach NASSCOM. Only then can we gather the resources that will be needed to monitor, and slow down the sale of pirated games." Although necessary, such a monitoring body would be currently hard to form, according to Sachin. "Extensive measures are not being taken to curb this activity for reasons of economy. It's all about making the right move at the right

time—money spent on anti-piracy initiatives, must be recoverable through game sales, which will not happen given the small numbers currently involved in this trade. The industry is pretty much stagnant. This

year saw no real growth, an extremely dangerous scenario," he says.

People think nothing of buying an illegal game copy, or downloading the latest games from peer to peer networks. It is possible to get hold of illegal copies for as little as Rs 200. "The ideal price-point for a game is Rs 200," agrees Sachin, "a consumer survey that we undertook suggests that people will pay up to Rs 500 for good games. Basically, games need to be priced on par with Audio CDs. Given current prices, it is truly impractical to purchase more than five or six games per year. Thus, you have a handful of people buying these games, while the rest justify themselves by citing high prices and then exchanging, borrowing, or downloading the games."

Ravi V (name changed to protect identity), is a regular gamer, and maintains an FTP site that serves as an exchange platform for illegal games and other software. He offers his view on piracy. "I would like to reward the developers for producing such amazing games by buying an original copy of the game. You can, however, buy pirated games for a trifle. I also burn, distribute and download pirated games. I do so because games aren't easily accessible in India, they don't release soon

enough, and even if they do, they are priced beyond my reach," he avers.

Unavailability of game titles in India is an oft-cited reason to pirate. There exists a sizeable demand for the latest game titles released by major publishing houses across the world. Sachin sheds some light on these issues. "The time-gap between an international release and local availability of a title has drastically reduced in the last year. The games we sell are basically decided on perceived demand of a title. Some of these titles may be pulled due to release slippages, or publishers losing the titles to failed negotiations, etc. You see, the publisher of a title chalks out the territories where the game can be distributed, according to what it feels would make good economic sense. Developers are also a part of this process, but there is a difference in their attitudes. While publishers look for maximum profitability, developers want the greatest visibility for their products. Certain titles such as *Elder Scrolls III: Morrowind* could not be published because the distributor was not interested in the South-East Asian market as a whole and in India in particular. Others, such as *Pool of Radiance*, were skipped, as the numbers sold would not have made good economic sense."

Economically-priced products can definitely help improve sales. Amit suggests that game prices can come down at the behest of the publishers. He explains that like any business', game distribution is a function of numbers. "To increase the numbers, we need to reduce the retail price, and make it affordable to the Indian pocket. For this, a product should be priced between Rs 100 to Rs 500. We cannot achieve this without the support of our international partners that are publishers."

However, there is an initial hit in terms of investment: someone has to take that risky first step and decide that a certain title should be sold at say, Rs 500 instead of Rs 1,500. This price difference has to come from someone's pocket—at least initially.

Hammering another nail in the coffin of legal game distribution, is the parallel gray-imports. Amit explains, "Consider someone who can purchase games from a close-out abroad and imports them into India. How do we fight that person?" The very fact that such a parallel market is thriving, indicates that there is indeed a sizeable demand for games. To counter

cially from the South Indian community. Our target audience is comfortable in English."

Price, piracy, paradox

A major cause for low sales of legal games is the rampant piracy. Relatively high prices act a primary deterrent to the popularity of legal versions. Sachin claims that "Piracy is huge; more than 90 per cent of games sold are pirated. It is fragmenting an already small market. A growing cause of this ailment is domestic piracy; wherein students burn and distribute games within a circle of friends." Amit agrees, pointing out that piracy is the reason why the market revenue is not increasing. He calls for a central body to monitor and reign in the renegade monster, that is the current illegal trade. "There is no organised body in the gaming industry to control (piracy). Another big hurdle is the lack of support from international publishers and distributors."

Approaching NASSCOM for a solution would require a flow of money that Amit feels is not practical for a single dis-

